DEV-10 · Remote Access & VPN Standard

What the VPN is actually for, who gets it, and why most people no longer need it.

Field	Value
Document ID	DEV-10
Version	1.0 · Known Good edition, by Kevin Zelman
Catalogue domain	C. Device Usage
Operating tier	Tier 2 — Advanced Technical Services, which already owns VPN.
Review cycle	Annually, and whenever a service moves from on-premises to Microsoft 365.
Related existing policy	Your organization's internet and network usage policy, if it has one. This standard puts it into practice.

1. Purpose

This document says what the organization’s VPN is for, who is entitled to it, and under what conditions — so that it is granted deliberately rather than by default, and so that a VPN ticket has an owner and a runbook.

VPN failure tickets are a classic example of tickets that sit past their service target. Part of the reason they age is that nothing states who VPN is for or what a working state looks like, so there is no obvious owner and no definition of done.

2. Two populations, one technology

> **The same tool is serving two very different situations, and only one of them is intended.**
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> Staff who need to reach on-premises resources from off site. This is the purpose, and it is legitimate and shrinking.
>
> People using a VPN to hide where they are signing in from. This tends to surface alongside repeated account blocks and a suspicion of credential sharing, and the usual response is a verbal instruction not to use a VPN or share access. That instruction is correct, but it is only spoken.
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> Writing the rule down serves both. Staff get a supported service with a clear entitlement. The second case becomes a published rule the organization can point to, rather than an instruction one staff member gave once.

3. What the VPN is for — and what it is not

The VPN is for	The VPN is not for
Reaching on-premises systems that are not published for external access — file shares while they still exist, internal administrative interfaces, network equipment management.	Reaching Microsoft 365. Outlook, Teams, SharePoint and OneDrive work from anywhere and do not need it. This misunderstanding drives a large share of VPN tickets.
Administrative access to infrastructure, by IT staff, from a compliant device.	Making a personal device “safe”. The VPN protects the connection, not the endpoint (DEV-07).
A specific application that genuinely requires an on-site source address.	Bypassing a geographic or network restriction, whether the organization’s or somebody else’s.
Vendor access to a named system, time-boxed (ACC-11).	Concealing where you are signing in from, or letting somebody else appear to be you (ACC-15 §3).

The first row of the right-hand column is worth saying to every requester: if what you need is email, Teams or your files, you do not need the VPN and it will not make them work better. Answering that once, in writing, removes a recurring ticket category.

4. Who gets it

Population	Entitlement	Basis
IT staff, Tiers 2–4	Yes, standing.	Infrastructure access is the job.
Staff with a stated on-premises need	On request, with the need named.	Reviewed annually; removed when the need ends.
Staff generally	Not by default.	Microsoft 365 does not require it (§3).
Temporary workers	Only where the specific role requires an on-premises system, approved by the supervisor and time-boxed to the engagement.	ACC-09.
Non-staff accounts (members, volunteers, customers)	No.	§7.
Vendors and contractors	Time-boxed, to a named system, with a sponsor.	ACC-11.
Guests	No.	ACC-10 §5.

5. Conditions of use

- Multifactor authentication is required. No exceptions, including for IT staff.

- The connecting device must be organization-owned and compliant (DEV-02), or a personal device meeting DEV-07 where that is permitted for the role.
- Split tunnelling is configured so that Microsoft 365 traffic does not traverse the VPN. This improves performance for the user and reduces load on the concentrator — and it reinforces §3 by making the distinction visible.
- Sessions have a maximum duration and re-authenticate. A VPN session that persists for weeks is an unmonitored standing connection.
- Use is logged. Logs are used for troubleshooting and security investigation, per ACC-15 §6.
- The Internet & Network Usage Policy applies to VPN traffic exactly as it does on site.

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6. Requesting and removing it

1. The request states the specific on-premises system needed and why Microsoft 365 does not serve it. Tier 2 checks that answer honestly — most requests resolve here without a grant.
2. The manager approves for staff; the supervisor for temporary workers; the sponsor for vendors.
3. Confirm MFA is registered and the device is compliant before granting.
4. Grant through a group, never individually (M365-11 §2), so review and removal work.
5. Set a review date. Annual for staff, end-of-engagement for temporary workers, contract-end for vendors.
6. Remove on separation and on role change (ACC-01 §6.2, §7.2) — this is one of the entitlements most often left behind at a mover.
7. Remove at review where the stated need no longer exists. The need was named at grant precisely so this question is answerable.

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7. The non-staff question

Non-staff accounts do not receive organization VPN access. Everything they need, such as Microsoft 365 and the portals, is published for access from anywhere.

Separately, and more importantly: using a personal VPN or proxy to obscure the location an organization account signs in from, or to enable somebody else to sign in as you, is prohibited under ACC-15 §3. That is now a written rule rather than an instruction given in a difficult conversation.

> **A caution worth holding**
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> VPN use is not evidence of wrongdoing. People use VPNs for privacy, on public Wi-Fi, and because a device came with one enabled. People who travel or work abroad may use one routinely and entirely legitimately.
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> It becomes relevant only alongside other indicators — the ACC-05 §5 repeat ladder, unfamiliar sign-in patterns, or an account blocked repeatedly. Treating VPN use alone as suspicious would be both wrong and corrosive.

8. Where this is going

The VPN's scope shrinks with every service that moves. Retiring the old network drives removes one of the largest remaining reasons staff need it (M365-13), and application publishing through Entra can remove most of the rest.

- Each time a service moves to Microsoft 365 or is published through Entra, review whether the VPN entitlements that existed for it can be withdrawn.
- The target is a small VPN population — IT staff and a named list — rather than a general staff entitlement.
- This is worth stating as a direction because it changes how requests should be handled today: the question is "what do you need to reach, and can we publish it instead?", not "should you have VPN?".

9. Service levels

Activity	Commitment (per GOV-06)
VPN not connecting, entitled user blocked from work	P2 — 4 coverage hours.
VPN down for multiple users	P1 at Tier 3.
New VPN request, need stated and approved	P3 — 3 coverage days.
Request where Microsoft 365 already serves the need	Answered at Tier 1 in the conversation. Not a ticket that ages.
Removal on separation or role change	With the ACC-01 procedure.
Annual entitlement review	Tier 2, on schedule.

10. Records

Record	Held in	Retention
Entitlement register: person, stated need, approver, review date	IT register	Live + 3 years
Requests declined because M365 serves the need	Ticket	1 year — useful evidence for §8
Connection logs	VPN platform	Per M365-16
Annual review outcomes	Ticket	3 years

11. Related documents

ID	Title	Relationship
Internet Policy	Your organization's internet and network usage policy	The governing policy. This standard operationalises it.
ACC-15	Acceptable Use & Credential-Sharing Standard	§3 — VPN misuse, and §7 here.

ID	Title	Relationship
ACC-05	Account Lockout Triage & Escalation	Where VPN use becomes relevant as one indicator among several.
DEV-02	Device Compliance & Configuration Baseline	Condition of use.
DEV-07	Personally-Owned Device Access Standard	Personal devices connecting.
M365-13	File Share Retirement	Removes one of the largest remaining reasons for VPN.
ACC-01	Account Lifecycle	Removal at mover and leaver.
ACC-09 / ACC-11	Temporary worker / Vendor standards	Time-boxed entitlements.
GOV-06	Service Commitments	Supplies §9.

Appendix A — "Do I need the VPN?"

Tier 1 desk card, and the source for an end-user article. Most answers are no, and that is good news for the person asking.

	What do you need to reach?	Answer
1	Email, Teams, SharePoint, OneDrive	No VPN needed. These work from anywhere, and the VPN will not make them faster.
2	A portal — the staff portal, the knowledge base, a web app	No VPN needed.
3	A file on an old network drive	Yes for now — and it is moving to SharePoint, at which point you will not need it (M365-13).
4	An internal administrative system with no external address	Yes. State which system on the request.
5	Network equipment or a server	Yes, if you are IT.
6	"I just thought I should have it"	No. Ask what you are trying to do — there is usually a better answer.
7	A non-staff account asking for VPN	No. Everything they need is published (§7).